

Free kicks

Free kicks are one of the most common restarts in football. Most are quick and uneventful, but those near the opposition penalty area are some of the most dangerous moments in a match.

Restarts and set pieces [Read the rules guide](#)

Direct and indirect free kicks

Free kicks come in two types. The difference is whether a goal can be scored straight from the kick.

Direct free kick

A goal can be scored directly from the kick without anyone else touching the ball. Direct free kicks are awarded for fouls involving contact with an opponent, for handball, and for a small number of other physical offences.

Indirect free kick

The ball must touch another player after being kicked before a goal can be scored. Indirect free kicks are awarded for technical offences such as offside, dangerous play without contact, and some goalkeeper offences.

Referee signal

For an indirect free kick, the referee raises one arm above the head. The arm stays raised until the ball touches another player, goes out of play, or it is clear that a goal cannot be scored directly.

If the ball goes straight in

A direct free kick can be scored straight into the opponents' goal. If an indirect free kick goes straight into the opponents' goal without another touch, the restart is a goal kick. If any free kick is kicked directly into the team's own goal, the opponents get a corner.

How a free kick is taken

The basics are the same for both types of free kick.

The ball is usually placed where the offence happened and must be stationary before the kick. There are a few special cases, such as indirect free kicks awarded to the attacking team inside the opponents' goal area. The kicker can be any player in the team, although it is normally a specific player picked for the situation. The ball is in play as soon as it is clearly kicked and moves.

All opposing players must usually be at least 9.15 metres (10 yards) from the ball until the kick is taken, unless they are on their own goal line between the posts. If the free kick is taken by a team inside its own penalty area, opponents must also remain outside the penalty area until the ball is in play.

The defensive wall

When the free kick is close enough to threaten goal, defenders usually form a wall. A wall is a line of defenders standing shoulder-to-shoulder to block part of the goal. The wall must stand at least 9.15 metres from the ball, although it usually stands closer to that minimum than further away. The goalkeeper picks where the wall stands and how many players are in it.

Attacking players are not allowed to stand within one metre of the wall when it has three or more defenders. This stops attacking teams from blocking the goalkeeper's view at the moment of the kick.

Quick free kicks

Free kicks do not have to wait for everyone to be ready.

If the kicker takes the free kick quickly, before defenders have set up, the kick is still valid as long as the ball was on the right spot and stationary. Quick free kicks are common in midfield, where they let the team pass the ball forward before defenders can recover.

The referee may stop the team from taking a quick free kick if a card needs to be shown, if the ball is not on the right spot, or if another interruption needs to happen first. In some situations, play can restart quickly and the card is shown at the next stoppage.

Indirect free kick offences

A small number of specific offences lead to an indirect free kick rather than a direct one.

Offside

An attacker being involved in active play from an offside position.

Dangerous play without contact

Playing in a way the referee considers dangerous to opponents, even though no contact was made.

Goalkeeper handling restrictions

A goalkeeper handling the ball after a deliberate kicked pass from a teammate, handling it directly from a teammate's throw-in, or touching it with the hand or arm after releasing it before another player has touched it.

Preventing goalkeeper release

Stopping the goalkeeper from releasing the ball from the hands, or trying to kick the ball while the goalkeeper is releasing it.

Impeding without contact

Blocking an opponent's path without making contact and without playing the ball.

Dissent or verbal offences

Offences such as dissent or offensive, insulting or abusive language are punished with an indirect free kick if play is stopped for them.

Goalkeeper time limit

Goalkeepers cannot hold the ball indefinitely.

Under the Laws, if a goalkeeper controls the ball with their hands or arms inside their penalty area for more than eight seconds, the restart is a corner kick to the other team, not an indirect free kick.

Free kicks near goal

Direct free kicks within shooting range are a real attacking weapon.

Within around 25 metres of goal, a direct free kick gives the kicker a serious chance to score. Specialist takers practise their technique on the training ground and aim for either the corner over the wall or a low shot through it.

From wider angles or further out, free kicks are usually crossed into the box rather than shot directly. The team treat it as a set piece, with rehearsed runs, blocks and second-ball positions.